

Election

doc-election

Soteriology · Election · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.912
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Before the foundation of the world, God chose a people for salvation in Christ; whether election is unconditional (Calvinist) or based on foreseen faith (classical Arminian/Brethren) is a divided question.

In plain language

The words at the center of this question are lexically clear. In Ephesians 1:4 the verb 'he chose' (exelexato) has God as its subject and 'us' as its object, set 'in him' and dated 'before the foundation of the world'. Ephesians 1:5 adds 'having predestined' (proorisas), governed by the good pleasure of his will. Romans 8:29-30 runs an unbroken chain: those God 'foreknew' (proegno) he also 'predestined' (prooorisen), called, justified, and glorified. Romans 9:11 says the twins had done nothing good or bad so that God's 'purpose according to election' (prothesis kat eklogen) might stand, and Romans 9:16 says it is not of the one who wills (thelo) or runs but of God who shows mercy (eleao). First Peter 1:1 calls the readers 'chosen ones' (eklektois). Behind all this stands the Old Testament verb 'choose' (bachar), used 170 times, where God chooses Israel to be his people. So the plain claim, that God chose a people for salvation in Christ, rests on solid and wide lexical ground. What the words do not settle is the basis of that choice and its object. The Greek choosing verb 'choose, pick out' (eklegomai) most often picks the apostles, the nation, or a portion, not individuals unto salvation, so the verb alone does not say the chosen are individual believers. The term 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) carries two senses in plain use: God knowing in advance who would believe, which would make the choice respond to foreseen faith, or God setting his regard on persons in advance, which would make it rest on his own will. Its only other use, in Acts 2:23, sits next to the word for a settled plan (boule), which leans toward the second sense, yet the bare word allows the first. Romans 9 leans hard toward a choice grounded in mercy alone, but its quotation of Malachi about Jacob and Esau speaks first of nations, which keeps a corporate reading open. Second Thessalonians 2:13 names both 'belief of the truth' (pistei aletheias) and 'sanctification of the Spirit' (hagiasmo pneumatos) inside the saving choice without ordering them. For these reasons the lexical pattern affirms the shared core but stays genuinely divided on whether election is unconditional or grounded in foreseen faith, and whether its object is individuals or a body in Christ, which is exactly the question the proposition flags as contested.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0977	ἔλεξα	bachar	to choose	170
G0025	ἀγαπήσα	agapaō	to love	
G0038	ἁγιασμῶ	hagiasmos	holiness	
G0138	αἰρέομαι	haireomai	to choose	3
G1344	ἐδικαίωσεν	dikaioō	to justify	
G1586	ἐκλέγομαι	eklegomai	to select	22

G1588	ἐκλεκτός	eklektos	select	23
G1589	ἐκλογή	ekloge	selecting	7
G1653	ἐλεάω	eleao	to have mercy	32
G2309	θέλοντος	thelō	to will/desire	
G2596	κατὰ	kata	according to	
G2602	καταβολῆς	katabolē	beginning	
G3404	ἐμίσησα	miseō	to hate	
G3627	οἰκτιρήσω	oikteirō	to have compassion	
G4267	προγινώσκω	proginosko	to know/choose	5
G4268	πρόγνωσις	prognosis	foreknowledge	2
G4286	πρόθεσις	prothesis	purpose	12
G4309	προορίζω	proorizo	to predestine	5
G4632	σκεῦος	skeuos	vessel	23
G4645	σκληρύνει	sklērunō	to harden	

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The vocabulary of choosing is lexically secure and spread across the whole Bible (pan-canonical) with God as subject. In the Old Testament the verb 'choose' (bachar) occurs 170 times across 162 verses with God choosing Israel as his people (Deuteronomy 7:6-7), and in the New Testament the verb 'choose, pick out' (eklegomai) in Ephesians 1:4 ('he chose us in him before the foundation of the world', exelexato hemas en auto pro kataboles kosmou) and the noun 'choosing, election' (ekloge) in Romans 9:11 and the adjective 'chosen' (eklektos) in 1 Peter 1:1 carry the same act forward, with the verb 'mark out beforehand, predestine' (proorizo) in Ephesians 1:5 and Romans 8:29-30. So the bare proposition that God chose a people for salvation in Christ before time is well grounded. But the contested axis, whether that choice is unconditional or grounded in foreseen faith, and whether its object is individuals or a corporate body in Christ, is not fixed by the lemmas (dictionary base forms). The verb 'choose' (eklegomai) is uniformly middle voice (a Greek voice in which the subject acts with reference to itself) but its dominant attested object is non-salvific (the apostles, the nation, a portion), so it does not by itself name individuals chosen unto salvation. The noun 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) in Romans 8:29 and 1 Peter 1:2 is polysemous (carries multiple senses) between anticipatory knowledge of response and covenantal fore-regard, and the words do not adjudicate. The lexical data is therefore materially contested between defensible readings.

Scripture

Eph.1.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1586 ἐξελέξατο, G2602 καταβολῆς

Force. The completed past action ('he chose', exelexato, tagged V-AMI-3S, that is a third-person singular aorist middle indicative form of the verb 'choose') has God as subject and 'us' (hemas) as object, set 'in him' (en auto), and dated 'before the foundation of the world' (pro kataboles kosmou). The lexical force fixes the timing as pretemporal (before time began), the agent as God, and the sphere as in Christ. But the following infinitive 'to be holy and blameless' (einai hagious kai amomous) names the goal of the choice, not its ground or condition, and the closing phrase 'in love' (en agape) sits at the verse boundary so that it can attach either to the holiness clause here or to the predestining of the next verse, which the grammar does not settle.

Eph.1.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4309 προορίσας, G2596 κατὰ

Force. The completed-past-action participle 'having predestined' (proorisas) governs 'unto adoption' (eis huiiothesian) and is qualified by 'according to the good pleasure of his will' (kata ten eudokian tou thelematos autou). The phrase locates the determining cause in God's own will and good pleasure, which the unconditional reading (the view that God's choice rests on his will alone, not on foreseen human faith) leans on. But the verb 'predestine' (proorizo) by itself states only that a boundary or destiny was set in advance, and the prepositional 'according to' phrase (kata) names the standard of the act, not whether foreseen human response is included within that good pleasure.

Rom.8.29 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4267 προέγνω, G4309 προώρισεν

Force. The clause places 'he foreknew' (proegno, tagged V-2AAI-3S, a third-person singular second aorist active indicative, that is a completed past action) syntactically prior to 'he predestined' (prooorisen), in a chain governed by the relative pronoun 'whom' (hous). The foreseen-faith reading (the view that God's choice responds to faith he sees in advance) takes 'he foreknew' (proegno) as foreknowledge of the believing response that conditions the predestining. The unconditional reading takes 'he foreknew' (proegno) as God setting covenantal regard on persons, supported by Romans 11:2 where the same verb has a corporate object, 'his people whom he foreknew' (ton laon autou hon proegno). The verb establishes order but its object here is unstated, so it does not adjudicate the content of the foreknowledge.

Rom.8.30 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4309 προώρισεν, G1344 ἐδικαίωσεν

Force. The unbroken chain 'he predestined, he called, he justified, he glorified' (prooorisen, ekalesen, edikaïosen, edoxasen) ties each completed past action (aorist) to the same relative-pronoun antecedent 'whom' (hous), so the same group is carried through every link without loss. The lexical pattern of an inviolable chain supports a definite people whose end is secured, but it does not by itself disclose whether entry into the chain is conditioned on foreseen faith.

Rom.9.11 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1589 ἐκλογὴν, G4286 πρόθεσις

Force. The genitive-absolute construction (a Greek phrase in the 'of-X' grammatical form that supplies background to the main clause) 'the twins not yet born and having done nothing good or bad' (mepo gennethenton mede praxanton ti agathon e phaulon) sets the timing of the choice before any human action, so that 'the purpose of God according to election' (he kat eklogen prothesis tou theou) might stand. The MACULA-Greek tagging (a morphology dataset that tags Greek words with their parsed forms) confirms the noun is 'purpose' (prothesis, Strong's G4286), distinct from the verb 'will' (thelo), and 'election' (ekloge) is Strong's G1589. The temporal clause and the qualifier 'not of works but of him who calls' (ouk ex ergon all ek tou kalountos, verse 12) are the lexical backbone of the unconditional reading. The corporate reading (the view that the choice is of a people, not individuals unto salvation) notes that the case in view is the elder-younger reversal of two named heads of nations.

Rom.9.13 · complicates · genre: epistle · figures: idiom

Key terms. G0025 ἠγάπησα, G3404 ἐμίσησα

Force. The citation of Malachi 1:2-3, 'I loved Jacob but Esau I hated' (ton Iakob egapesa, ton de Esau emisesa), uses 'I loved' (egapesa, from the verb agapao, Strong's G0025) and 'I hated' (emisesa, from the verb miseo, Strong's G3404). The Hebrew source uses 'love' (ahab, Strong's H0157) and 'hate' (sane, Strong's H8130) of Jacob (proper noun, Strong's H3290) and Esau (proper noun, Strong's H6215), and Malachi's own context speaks of the nations Israel and Edom, since verses 3-4 describe Edom's territory. The loving and hating pairing functions as a Semitic comparative idiom (a Hebrew way of speaking) of preference and rejection, and its corporate national reference complicates a directly individual-salvific reading.

Rom.9.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1653 ἐλεήσω, G3627 οἰκτιρήσω

Force. The quotation of Exodus 33:19, 'I will have mercy on whom I have mercy' (eleeso hon an eleo), uses the subjunctive (a mood expressing possibility or contingency) with the particle 'an' (a particle that signals indefiniteness) to express God's free self-determination of the objects of his mercy. The lexical force places the choosing of the recipients of mercy in God's own freedom rather than in a prior claim upon him.

Rom.9.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2309 θέλοντος, G1653 ἐλεῶντος

Force. The summary 'not of him who wills nor of him who runs but of God who shows mercy' (ou tou thelontos oude tou trechontos alla tou eleontos theou) lexically subordinates human 'willing' (thelo) and running to divine 'mercy' (eleao). The threefold participial contrast (three matched 'who'-clauses built on participles) is the strongest single-clause support for an unconditional ground within this passage.

Rom.9.18 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1653 ἐλεεῖ, G4645 σκληρύνει

Force. The parallel 'he has mercy on whom he wills and he hardens whom he wills' (hon thelei eleei, hon de thelei sklerunei) balances 'have mercy' (eleao) against 'harden' (skleruno) under the single governing verb 'will' (thelo). The lexical symmetry shows the same divine willing operating on both mercy and hardening, which the unconditional reading takes as decisive and which the other lens reads against the redemptive-historical frame (the storyline of God's saving acts across time) of Pharaoh in verse 17.

1Pet.1.1 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1588 ἐκλεκτοῖς, G4268 πρόγνωσιν

Force. The recipients are addressed as 'chosen ones' (eklektois), and 1 Peter 1:2 grounds this 'according to the foreknowledge of God the Father' (kata prognosin theou patros). The MACULA-Greek (a morphology dataset that tags Greek words with their parsed forms) gloss of 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) is simply foreknowledge, and the only other New Testament occurrence of the noun, Acts 2:23, pairs it with 'determinate plan or counsel' (boule). The pairing with 'plan or counsel' (boule) gives the determinative reading real footing, while the bare lexeme (the dictionary form by itself) leaves the anticipatory-knowledge reading open, so the verse is the principal text the two lenses contest.

2Thess.2.13 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0138 εἴλατο, G0038 ἀγιασμῶ

Force. God 'chose you' (heilato hymas, from the verb 'choose for oneself', haireomai, which always appears in the middle voice form, attested only three times), 'for salvation' (eis soterian), 'in sanctification of the Spirit and belief of the truth' (en hagio smō pneumatō kai pistei aletheias). The verse names 'belief' (pistis) inside the sphere or means of the saving choice, which the foreseen-faith reading uses, while 'sanctification of the Spirit' (hagiasmos pneumatō) is named alongside it as a divine work, and the words do not order belief and divine sanctification causally. The SBLGNT text (the SBL Greek New Testament edition) reads 'firstfruits' (aparchen), where the marked apparatus (the critical-edition list of textual variants) carries the alternative 'from the beginning' (ap arches).

Deut.7.6 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H0977 בָּחַר

Force. God 'chose' (bachar) Israel to be a people for his own possession, 'treasured people' (am segullah), and verse 7 repeats the verb, 'and he chose' (wayyivchar), stating the choice was not because they were many but because the LORD loved them and kept the oath to the fathers. The Old Testament choosing verb 'choose' (bachar) here grounds election as the selection of a corporate people, and verse 7 names the ground as God's love and prior oath rather than any merit, which the New Testament choosing language draws upon, since the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) regularly renders 'choose' (bachar) with 'choose, pick out' (eklegomai).

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Rom.9.10	Gen.25.21	tsk	1
Rom.9.12	Gen.25.22	tsk	1
Rom.9.13	Mal.1.2	tsk	1
Rom.9.17	Exod.9.16	tsk	1
Rom.9.17	Exod.10.1	tsk	1
Eph.1.4	Deut.7.6	tsk	1
1Pet.1.2	1Pet.2.9	tsk	1
2Thess.2.13	2Thess.2.16	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Rom.8.29 · addressed

The placement of 'he foreknew' (proegno) before 'he predestined' (prooorisen) is real and is what the foreseen-faith lineage rests on. It is addressed by noting that the verb 'foreknow' (proginosko) occurs 5 times, and where its object is named it can be a people (Romans 11:2, 'his people whom he foreknew') which favors covenantal fore-regard, or an ordinary prior acquaintance (Acts 26:5). The verb here leaves its object unstated, so it establishes order without establishing whether the thing foreknown is faith or persons. It therefore counts toward dispute rather than toward a single verdict.

1Pet.1.2 · addressed

'According to the foreknowledge of God' (kata prognosin theou) is read by one lineage as anticipatory knowledge of response and by the other as determinative fore-regard. The noun 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) occurs only twice (here and Acts 2:23), and the Acts occurrence pairs 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) with 'determinate counsel' (boule), which gives the determinative reading footing, while the bare lexeme (the dictionary form by itself) covers anticipatory knowledge too. The verse is held as genuinely two-sided and contributes to the disputed verdict.

Rom.9.13 · addressed

The Malachi 1:2-3 citation refers in its source context to the nations Israel and Edom, since Malachi 1:3-4 describes Edom's land, so the 'I loved' (agapao) and 'I hated' (miseo) language is corporate before it is individual. This is a real complication for an individual-salvific reading, but it does not remove the pretemporal-choice language of Romans 9:11, so the basis and object remain contested rather than settled.

2Thess.2.13 · unaddressed

Not resolved because the verse names both 'belief of the truth' (pistei aletheias) and 'sanctification of the Spirit' (hagiasmo pneumatou) within the saving choice, and the lexical data alone cannot order belief and divine sanctification causally. The MACULA text reads 'firstfruits' (aparchen), with the apparatus (the critical-edition list of textual variants) marking the alternative 'from the beginning' (ap arches), and the from-the-beginning reading would more directly favor a pretemporal salvific choice. The ambiguity is left standing and feeds the disputed verdict.

Concordance traversed

G1586, G1589, G1588, G4309, G4267, G4268, G4286, G1653, G4632, G0138, G0025, G3404, H0977

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

2Thess.2.13/aparchen-vs-ap-arches at 2Thess.2.13: impact minor. The MACULA-Greek and MorphGNT SBLGNT text reads 'firstfruits' (aparchen), and the apparatus marker (the critical-edition note flagging a textual variant) carries the alternative 'from the beginning' (ap arches). The from-the-beginning reading would more directly support a pretemporal salvific choice, but both readings keep God as the choosing agent and neither settles the unconditional versus foreseen-faith axis, so the impact on this verdict is minor.

The anchor verses sit outside the published scope of the critical edition of New Testament textual variants (ECM apparatus). The `not_in_ecm_scope` flag was true in the bundle and the bundle supplied no variant units. The known 'firstfruits' (aparchen) versus 'from the beginning' (ap arches) reading at 2 Thessalonians 2:13 is recorded from the SBLGNT (the SBL Greek New Testament edition) apparatus marker, but it shifts emphasis without overturning the disputed verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. unconditional_election, conditional_election_foreseen_faith, corporate_election

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

unconditional_election: for · Reads Romans 9:11-18 and Ephesians 1:5 as grounding the choice in God's purpose, will, and mercy prior to and apart from human works or foreseen response, treating 'he foreknew' (proegno) in Romans 8:29 as covenantal fore-regard of persons (compare Romans 11:2) and 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) in 1 Peter 1:2 as determinative, supported by its pairing with 'plan, counsel' (boule) in Acts 2:23, and reading 'not of him who wills nor runs but of God who shows mercy' (Romans 9:16) as decisive.

conditional_election_foreseen_faith: for · Reads the order 'he foreknew' (proegno) before 'he predestined' (prooorisen) in Romans 8:29 and 'according to foreknowledge' (kata prognosin) in 1 Peter 1:2 as foreknowledge of the believing response that conditions the predestining, since 'foreknowledge' (prognosis) can mean anticipatory knowledge, and reads 'belief of the truth' (pistei aletheias) in 2 Thessalonians 2:13 as the foreseen condition named within the saving choice. On this lens the choosing verbs are real and pretemporal but respond to faith God foresees.

corporate_election: complicates · Reads the choosing vocabulary against its dominant attested object: the Old Testament verb 'choose' (bachar) chooses Israel as a corporate people (Deuteronomy 7:6-7), the New Testament verb 'choose, pick out' (eklegomai) most often chooses the apostles or the nation rather than individuals unto salvation, the 'in him' (en auto) of Ephesians 1:4 is corporate, and the Malachi 1:2-3 Jacob and Esau citation is national. On this lens Romans 9 addresses redemptive-historical roles (the roles peoples play within the storyline of God's saving acts) of peoples before it addresses the basis of individual salvation.

The lemmas (dictionary base forms) establish a real pretemporal divine choice of a people but do not by themselves fix either its basis (unconditional versus foreseen faith) or its object (individuals versus corporate in Christ), so 'comparing Scripture with Scripture' (analogia scripturae) is invoked by every lineage. Progressive revelation (the principle that God's self-disclosure unfolds across the biblical storyline) matters because Romans 9 argues the case by quoting Genesis, Exodus, and Malachi, and the Old Testament verb 'choose' (bachar) stands behind the New Testament 'choose, pick out' (eklegomai) through Greek Old Testament (Septuagint) usage. The primary method is redemptive-historical (reading the text within the storyline of God's saving acts across time) because the verdict turns on the covenantal arc from the choosing of Israel to the choosing in Christ.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The question stem is already balanced. It affirms only the shared claim that God chose a people for salvation in Christ before the foundation of the world, and it explicitly names the unconditional versus foreseen-faith question as a divided question rather than asserting either side. The parenthetical labels Calvinist and classical Arminian or Brethren name the lineages without ranking them, so no tradition-specific taxonomy is smuggled into the proposition itself. The stem is therefore not verdict-preloaded, and the verdict is derived on the original stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Eph.1.4
morphology	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Rom.9.11
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4309
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4268
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rom.8.29
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Deut.7.6
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.9.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Rom.9.17
variant	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	2Thess.2.13

License audit

NOT SAFE TO PUBLISH

Reason. Two sources are non-redistributable for bulk reuse. The morphology and middle-voice tagging that anchor the 'choose, pick out' (eklegomai) and 'purpose' (prothesis) observations were queried from MACULA-Greek (CC-BY-NC-4.0), and the 2 Thessalonians 2:13 'firstfruits' (aparchen) versus 'from the beginning' (ap arches) reading was confirmed from SBLGNT-text (SBLGNT-EULA). The CC-BY-4.0, CC-BY-SA-4.0, and public-domain sources could carry most claims, but the MACULA morphology and SBLGNT apparatus marker are load-bearing for the voice and variant findings, so the bundle is marked not safe to publish until those dependencies are replaced.

Source	License	Redistribute
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
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TSK	public_domain	yes
SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

lexically-disputed · complicating-unresolved